

A Compression Between The Studying Material in History as a way to Deduce State Intentions

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(1) Introduction

His research topic is about a subject the reader is most likely greatly familiar with – history lessons. Perhaps, the reader would have expected the existence of certain events relevant to high-school students all over the world, such as the Cold War, colonialism in the 16th-20th centuries, the First and Second World Wars (written as WWI and WWII respectively), Maoism, Nazism, and Communism. However, this is not the case; in different states and countries, there is a variety of topics being taught. The obvious question that comes up as a result of this fact, is, why? If some events are so important to mankind, how is it that some states are completely missing them?

Our research focuses on three main questions:

1. What is being taught in different countries as part of their history lessons?
2. What does it teach about the state's intentions?
3. How history lessons differ from Israel?

This whole research project started when I asked my history teacher, Sarit, why Israel choose to ignore International and even Jewish history, if it doesn't fit the government's intentions (more information in chapter (2.1)). According to her, each nation (In Israel's case, Zionism) tries to keep their intentions when teaching history, and that it is done internationally – not just in Israel.

(2) A Review of The National History Curriculum in different countries

(2.1) ~ *Appendix*

In order to answer the first research question – “what is being taught in different countries as part of their history lessons?”, I tried to extract information from the most obvious source of information – the official syllabus of the state. In this process, I ran into the following problems:

- The official syllabus of the state is usually written in the native language of the place. In cases like USA and Israel it wasn't a problem, but for France, Germany and the UK I've had to rely on a translation. I mostly used google translate.
- Sometimes the syllabus is not homogeneous across the state or not publicly available (e.g. China).

Note that in European there are two “routes” – the first one is a technical collage, and the second is general collage. The so-called “collage” does not convey the American meaning of the word, but rather means a school for 7-12th grades. It creates an awful difference in future opportunities for the child that is decided for him at a young age (when they are twelve).

(2.2) ~ Israel

Probably the simplest to explain out of all of the programs. It's divided up into 3 categories^[1]:

1. WWII & Holocaust
2. Nationality & Zionism
3. Building a Country [Israel]

Just by this names it's pretty clear how chapters 1 and 2 are structured: general history (General Nationality, World War II) and alongside that, the Jewish part of that more general event/phenomenon (Zionism/Holocaust). chapter 3 is different as it contains no references to global events. Events after the 50th outside to Israel are missing too. It's hard to understand the current world order without a proper knowledge of the late 20th century.

Even though it may seem like the program is mostly focused on historical events related primarily to Judaism, it is a big advancement since earlier version of the program. 10 years ago, event in WWII that are not related to the Holocaust, have not been learned. Same applies for general nationality^[2].

Under problem is the misleading picture that painted when viewing events like The Holocaust and even Jewish migration through the lens of just Zionism. For example, the Bund, the most popular party and Youth movements, is not mentioned in the books even once (!)^[4]. Jewish Immigration as a result from non-zionistic intentions is not being talked, etc.

(2.3) ~ France

Perhaps the best example of a curriculum that tries to convey a feeling of being wide and comprehensive, but when you dig in, you find a clear bias towards certain attitude. First of all, we (by "we" I'm referring to me only) need to understand two things about the education system in France as a whole:

- The Final exam in History technically is an exam in both History and Geography. In practice, it has little to do with Geography.
- France uses the weird European high-school system. There are differences between the technical and general school, that I'll not cover.

In short, the studies material consists mostly of:

1. The French revolution
2. The First and the Second World War
3. France and the world since 1945

I would want to emphasize how the French History Program views the French revolution^[3]:

- Public execution of people during the Napoleonic Wars, forcing Roman law onto Non-French citizens, and roughly a million civilians starving and dying, became "legal imperialism" in the History Programs.
- Let's look at The Reign of Terror, a period between period between 1793-1794, on which approximately [source needed] 16 thousand people murdered directly in the Guillotine (and 25K indirectly), sometime because they were enemies of the Reign, and sometimes just to convey a feeling of fear and terror.

The general schools Program uses the word "terror" just 4 times in the document. The Reign of Terror get a full 3 sentences mention in the whole 14-pages long document. The reign of terror is not a part of the material for technical schools.

- In the beginning of the revolution hundreds of (many time innocent) aristocrats (or people that chosen to be called aristocrats) were murdered every day. In the Program, it translates to "the

period was intense”.

- The emphasis is the Program is vastly on the national aspect of it. The word “Nation” and its derivatives are written 63 and 34 times in the general and technical Program respectively.

With that said, the Program rightfully criticizes the actions of the France in regard to colonialism. So, while the Program has no problem criticizing France as a country (e.g. in the case of colonialism) it fails to give a merely objective view on anything related to France as a nation.

I would want to remark the fact that the Program for General school covers events that happened in the world after 1945, such as the South-Africa Genocide and The Cold War. With that said, a substantial focus of this chapter is on changes in France itself.

(2.4) $\sim$ *New-York City*

There is not central history program in the US as a whole – the education is largely dependent on state. On a personal note, it was relatively easy to write this subchapter, since (1) it’s written in English, and not French (2) it’s just one long, clearly sectioned document, not 38 different documents that half of them covers that same subject (3) there’s no history lessons in new york city.

Right. No History lessons. Instead of that, there is what’s called “Social Studies”. The exam in Social studies is divided up into 3 parts: US history, World History, and “Participation in Government” (which is unrelated to the topic and I’ll not cover it). Since the history part is jammed up with Geography, Economics, mostly “Social Study Practices”, which is another way to say that they’re being taught *how to learn history*, rather than *learning history*, it’s clear that history will be much less significant in compare to an actual history test.

Important highlight: even though the education is state-dependent, a general framework and skills required from social studies in general is suggested by a organization named NCSS (national council for the social studies). It does not appear to publish anything related to history specific, but rather, to describe general “themes” like “*technology*”, “*individuals and groups*”, “*time and change*”, and other non-specific things that does not relate to learning history by any way^[6]. Supposedly more than 50 states^[7]. Hence, by analyzing how terribly implemented those unified frameworks are in NYS, perhaps we can deduce how “Social Studies” looks in the rest of America.

One thing we can say in favor of the Social Studies framework, is that it’s extremely broad. Every major event – from the agricultural revolution, the ottoman empire, the Industrial Revolution, imperialism, WWI&II, the Cold War, the collapse of USSR etc. Nothing is covered to a great extent^[5]:

- There’s no mention of antisemitism in WWII (but one mention of the Holocaust).
- Students will learn about perestroika and Cold War, without learning what Communism is.
- Students will learn about WWII without learning what Nazism is. Nazism, Nazis, The Nazi Party, etc. are not mentioned even one time in the whole subsection dedicated to WWII.
- Some straight-up lies contained in the framework:
 - “In response to World War II and the Holocaust, the United States played a major role in efforts to prevent such human suffering in the future” (the official Program) – a contradiction to The Holocaust in Hungary.
 - Students will investigate Zionism [...] and Arab Nationalism – translated in reality into phrasing like “Zionism [is an] Extreme of extreme nationalism belief that Jews need a homeland in Palestine”^[8], in contradiction to the definition of Zionism
 - China is communist (??? this is just the name of the party) – “[...] that resulted in [...] communist-run People’s Republic of China”.

(3) Deduction and Comparison

In all of the countries above, the history of the state, **and especially the nationality** of the state, have played a critical role in the curriculum. Moreover, in some places, like New York, courses in patriotism are required by law^[10]. Moreover: competing ideologies have left behind, for example:

- In the case of New York, communism is not taught, while communist expansion does.
- In the case of Israel, The Bund and similar Non-Zionist organization are dismissed.
- France fails to criticize actions done in the name of Nationality.

Which shows how the intentions of the state itself are expressed in what the students are taught. With that said, all programs aims to cover a wide variety of topics that are non-related to the state itself.

In comparison the Israel, we found most countries has a bit more diverse curriculum in relation to general history. Mainly, The Col War is missing from the syllabus. Nevertheless, Israel has progressed towards a more general program in the last 7 years.

We conclude that on one hand there is a unified effort to bring the students to a place where they have a general knowledge about how most things in the world came into existence, while still leaning heavily towards teaching their own agenda.

One last substantial note, is that none of the programs are even mentions the history of eastern society like China and Japan (apart from a small part in New York's). Same applies for third world countries. It make sense considering the disconnection between the Eastern and the Western societies, but there is a possibility that it's a consequence of geopolitical tensions (a counterpoint for that argument is the lack of information about nonaligned countries, or even Arab countries that lean towards the west like the UAE, Saudi Arabia, etc.). Regardless of the reason, nonexistence of any information about the origin and the culture of the vast majority of the people in the world, that live outside to Europe, America and Russia – is a major problem.

(4) Conclusion

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A learner, at any country, has always to be always aware and critical of what being learned, as history can be twisted and viewed from different angles. Perhaps more importantly, is to be conscious of what is *not* learned, and why. As my history teacher once said – every history book has an agenda. The way major events like The Holocaust, The Cold War, and The French Revolution are being learned across the globe is different, and one will always push his agenda towards you.

We learned that nationality plays a big part in *what* and *how* things are learned. France what you to be proud you're french, Israel would like you to be proud you're Israeli, and so on. Those intentions are present in the history curriculum of each nation.

References.....

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- [2] Israel's Education Department ~ (2016-17) ~ [website](#)
- [3] France' National Ministry Education; Official Bulletin 22&25 for 2019 [still used today] ~ [website](#)
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- [7] About National Council for the Social Studies ~ [website](#)
- [8] 10th-grade NY review handout defines Zionism as 'extreme land-grabbing nationalism' ~ June 2025 ~ [website](#)
- [9] Definition of Zionism ~ Oxford Dictionary ~ [website](#)
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